

UNITED STATES GOVERNMENT

Memorandum

TO : Mr. Belmont

DATE: December 13, 1962

FROM : C. A. Evans

SUBJECT: PROPOSED TELEVISION SERIES
PREDICATED ON "THE FEDERAL
INVESTIGATORS" BY MIRIAM OTTENBERG

Tolson	✓
Belmont	✓
Mohr	✓
Wick	✓
Casper	✓
Callahan	✓
Conrad	✓
DeLoach	✓
Evans	✓
Gale	✓
Rosen	✓
Sullivan	✓
Tavel	✓
Trotter	✓
Tele. Room	✓
Holmes	✓
Gandy	✓

Mr. James Symington, Administrative Assistant to the Attorney General, has routinely forwarded a copy of a letter from the Attorney General to [redacted] of the Los Angeles Police Department acknowledging a letter from [redacted] with which he encloses a letter from Jack Webb, the television personality. The letter from Webb indicates he has acquired television rights to Ottenberg's book, "The Federal Investigators." Webb proposes to use some of the material in the book on his current television series and thereafter he is considering a new series to be called "Federal Investigators," utilizing still additional material. Webb states that on his current television series, "True," he has presented a few subjects dealing with the communist menace which he believes were effective.

A copy of the letter forwarded to the Bureau was also sent to Assistant Attorney General Miller of the Criminal Division. In this connection, Miller advised that he has received no indication as to what the Attorney General had in mind, it being noted that his acknowledgment merely stated he would be glad to look into the matter.

ACTION TO BE TAKEN:

ENCLOSURE

It would seem obvious that the Bureau should not become involved in this matter in any way. This TV series, if it ever materializes, will concern all of the federal investigative agencies. If there is to be any real interest in the TV series, this will necessitate reliance on the FBI. It would not have proper control, and whatever we do in this field should relate solely

- 1 - Mr. Mohr
- 1 - Mr. DeLoach

CAE:vap

56J (6)

CRIME RESEARCH

Memorandum to Mr. Belmont

to the FBI and not have our work intermingled with that of other investigative agencies. Accordingly, it is proposed that if Symington follows up and raises any question regarding this matter, he simply be informed that it would not be possible for us to participate in any such television series.

✓ ✓
LW Hm
I certainly agree. We
want no part of it.
X

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62-105473-30
ENCLOSURE

December 7, 1962

Dear

Thank you for your letter of November 21st
enclosing Jack Webb's own letter and plan for a
television program. I will be glad to look into it
and let you both know.

Sincerely,

b6
b7C

Robert F. Kennedy

Department of Police
150 N. Los Angeles Street
Los Angeles 12, California

BC: w/copy of incoming letter
Mr. Herbert J. Miller - Criminal Division

✓ Mr.
FBI

JWS/chp

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I would like to do the same in the self-same fashion to portray the Federal Investigator. Being ever mindful, as when we worked with Bill Parker's full approval and under [] supervision on the local level, to protect the confidentiality of reports, change or withhold names, etc.

But what we could do -- to borrow your own words from the book's forward: "The importance of the Federal Investigators to the health and safety of our country, in fields ranging from espionage to orange juice, is not widely enough recognized." We might be able to emphasize these agents' great contributions and quite possibly begin to give credit where it is most assuredly due.

Miriam will of course be closely associated with the project and assure factual competence in the various episodes.

THE PLAN -- You may be aware that I am currently involved in a television series carried on some 190 CBS stations entitled "TRUE." We have presented a few subjects dealing with the Communist menace which I believe -- and I don't wish to sound immodest -- were rather effective. We didn't editorialize, but simply presented the facts much the same as we did on "DRAGNET" as a dramatized report. We have been receiving requests for these films from people like Systems Incorporated to screen for their employees, from Mr. Bregger, whom I am told is the head of the President's anti-communism committee, and the like. Most of our press has been in the form of high praise. Therefore, we would be desirous of commencing immediately to use some of Miriam's material on "TRUE." Following this, we would like to compile a series to be called "FEDERAL INVESTIGATORS" utilizing still additional material.

Now, I am cognizant of the problems of working with the various agencies -- of many of the "do's" and "don'ts" and it will be our absolute desire to cooperate in the fullest measure with everyone

WARNER BROS.

PICTURES, INC.
WEST COAST STUDIOS
BURBANK, CALIFORNIA

November 21, 1963

b6

The Honorable Robert F. Kennedy
Attorney General of the United States
Department of Justice
Washington 25, D.C.

Dear Bob:

Our mutual good friend [redacted] has been kind enough to facilitate delivery of this letter to you, for which I am doubly grateful.

One -- It affords me the opportunity to communicate directly with you on a matter of great importance to me and I hope to you.

Two -- I would not wish to proceed with this project unless it embodied your personal blessing -- not, I am mindful, your endorsement, which I am fully aware you are in no position to offer and I am in no way requesting.

THE PROJECT -- I have just concluded a transaction with Miriam Ottenberg and her publishers, Prentice-Hall Inc., for the rights to her splendid and fascinating book "THE FEDERAL INVESTIGATORS." I confess it has been many moons since I have been so engrossed with like material from any source. Her writing is reminiscent of the approach we took a few years back with "DRAUGHT." She displays the honesty of approach, the obvious admiration she has for the unsung heroes -- the undercover investigator. We tried desperately to present this kind of picture of the American police officer.



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concerned and present the material stylishly, accurately and reflecting great credit to all. In short -- to be a proper, dignified "voice" for these agents who protect and defend our very lives. This, I can assure you, we will do.

In the presentation of similar material already on "TRUE," if we have opened one man's eyes -- if we have alerted that most precious area, the brain of one child, to the authentic portrayal of America's ideals, her principles, and the patriotic men and women who labor in her cause, it has been well worth the effort.

It is my earnest belief that television should be providing more of this fare -- providing it in hard-hitting, eminently honest, dramatically desirable form.

I think we could do some good with a project like this. But once again, we will go forward only if you think the project merits it.

I know how busy you are these days, and I thank you for taking the time to peruse this.

My warmest personal regards to you and yours.

Cordially,

Jack Webb

JW:jm